M.R. SHARAN
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Employment

Assistant Professor, University of Maryland Jan 2021-

Post-Doctoral Fellow, Center for Global Development July 2020 - Dec 2020
Research Associate, JPAL South Asia June 2012 – October 2013
Research Assistant, International Growth Center April 2011 – April 2012

Education

PhD, Harvard University 2014-2020

Thesis Title: *"Essays in Development Economics and Political Economy"*

M. A., Delhi School of Economics 2009-2011
B. A. (Hons), Hans Raj College, Delhi University 2006-2009

Classes Taught

AREC 869: Political Economy of Development
AREC 365: World Hunger, Population and Food Supplies
AREC 370: From Poverty to Progress: India's Political Economy in Transition

Published Research Papers

"Women Political Leaders, Corruption, and Learning: Evidence from a Large Public Program in India" (with Farzana Afridi and Vegard Iversen, *Economic Development and Cultural Change*, *66*(1), pp.1-30.)

"Learning to Govern: The Impact of Politicians' Peer Networks" (with Apurva Bamezai, Siddharth George, Siddharth Hari and Munish Sharma, *Accepted under the Phase-1 Pre-Results Track at the Journal of Development Economics*)

"The Short- and Long-Run Distributional Consequences of Political Reservations" (with Chinmaya Kumar, *Conditionally Accepted* at the *Journal of the European Economic Association*)

Book Chapter

Two Hundred and Fifty Thousand Democracies: A Review of Panchayati Raj in India (with Siddharth George and Vijayendra Rao), *Forthcoming* at the *Cambridge Companion to Indian Politics and Society*

Working Papers

"Do Elected Leaders Add Value? Evidence from a Natural Experiment in India" (with Abhishek Arora, Siddharth George, Nivedita Mantha and Vijayendra Rao)
Revise and Resubmit, American Economic Review

"The Impact of Women's Self Help Groups on Political Entry: Evidence from India" (with Iman Sen)
Revise and Resubmit, Economic Journal

"The Determinants and Consequences of Political Selection in the Developing World: Evidence from India" (with Apurva Bamezai, Siddharth George and Borui Sun)

"Complaint Resolution Systems and Local Governance: Experimental Evidence from Rural India" (with Chinmaya Kumar)
Under revision

"Safe Spaces or Elite Networks? Experimental Evidence on What Empowers Disadvantaged Groups" (with Apurva Bamezai, Siddharth George, Siddharth Hari and Munish Sharma)

"Does the Graduation Program Scale? Evidence from India" (with Abhijit Banerjee, Esther Duflo, Andrés Orduña Correcher, Jyoti Mukhopadhyay and Shagun Sabarwal)

"Collective Action and Public Service Delivery: Experimental Evidence from a Social Movement in India" (with Niharika Singh)

"Who, Not How Many: Local Council Design and Workfare Delivery in Rural India" (with Siddharth George and Nandini Gupta)

Papers in Preparation

"Affirmative Action, Attitudes and Social Networks: Evidence from Caste-Based Reservation in India" (with Emily Breza and Arun Chandrasekhar)

"Local Taxation and Development Outcomes" (with Abhishek Arora, Siddharth George, Vijayendra Rao)

Other Research Papers

Making the Bihar Caste Census Better, The India Forum, April 2023

Dispute Resolution mechanisms in Bihar (with Sabyasachi Das), Seminar, Feb 2023

"*The National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme in Rajasthan: Rationed Funds and their allocation across villages*" (with Himanshu and Abhiroop Mukhopadhyay), Economic and Political Weekly, 2015

"*Identifying BPL Households: A Comparison of Competing Approaches*", Economic and Political Weekly, 2011, pp.256-262

Public Writings

Bihar's unrealised potential, The Hindu, Dec 2025 (with Munish Sharma)

Bihari Mukhiyas: Handy & Held Back, Times of India, Nov 2025

Bihar's got bijli, sadak and pani now, but it's still missing foundation for prosperity, Indian Express, Oct 2025

Census that has to be more than a headcount, The Hindustan Times, Jul 2025

India needs a new decentralisation—let politicians manage people, experts handle policies, ThePrint, Sep 2024 (with Abhishek Arora, Siddharth George, Nivedita Mantha and Vijayendra Rao)

Nitish Kumar's survey and history of caste churn in Bihar, Indian Express, Oct 2023

Caste data's benefits and risks may be overblown, Hindustan Times, Aug 2023
Why we need the Bihar caste census (with M V Swaroop), July 2023

What we don't understand about prohibition in Bihar: It's popular, Dec 2022

Accurate Caste Data Can Propel Progress, Hindustan Times, July 2022

What the Bihar Model Got Right and Where it Missed the Mark, Times of India, Nov 2020.

How Caste Equations Continue to Shape Bihar's Economic Fortunes, Outlook, December 2021.

The particulars of social policy in India: Evidence, State capacity, and policy design (with Apurva Bamezai), Ideas for India, Sep 2018

Secular Hymns, Economic and Political Weekly, Vol. 53, Issue No. 47, 01 Dec, 2018

Remembering and Forgetting in Bihar, Economic and Political Weekly, Vol. 53, Issue No. 39, 29 Sep, 2018.

Book

Last Among Equals: Power, Caste and Politics in Bihar's Villages, Context, 2021.

Novel

Blue, HarperCollins, 2014.

Grants and Fellowships:

2025-26	Gates Foundation Bridge Grant	$20,000
2025-26	Notre Dame University Kellogg Institute (with Niharika Singh [University of Notre Dame])	$20,000
2024-25	ISLA Large Research Grant (with Niharika Singh [University of Notre Dame])	$20,000
2024-25	BIG Lab's Mezzanine Grant Award (with Niharika Singh [University of Notre Dame])	$40,000
2024-25	World Bank Research Funding (with Siddharth George [NUS, Singapore] and Vijayendra Rao [World Bank])	$50,000
2023-24	Ford Program Faculty Research Award (with Niharika Singh [UND])	$25,000
2023-24	The International Growth Centre (with Apurva Bamezai [UPenn], Siddharth George [NUS], Siddharth Hari [World Bank])	$82,000
2023-24	Gates Foundation	$250,000
2022-23	J-PAL Governance Initiative	$75,000
2022-23	J-PAL Governance Initiative	$169,510
2022-23	INCITE Grant (with Niharika Singh [UND])	$19,600
2022-23	Weiss Fund (with Apurva Bamezai [UPenn], Siddharth George [NUS], Siddharth Hari [World Bank])	$93,427
2022-23	World Bank Research Funding (with Siddharth George [NUS, Singapore] and Vijayendra Rao [World Bank])	$100,000
2021-22	UPIASI CSR Funding (with Apurva Bamezai (UPenn), Aashish Gupta (Harvard) and Harsha Thirumurthy (UPenn)	INR 4000000

2021-22	Georgetown University Small Grant (with Rajesh Veeraraghavan [Georgetown] and Iman Sen [University of Maryland])	$21,000
2021-22	Marshall Foundation Grant	$21,050
2021-22	World Bank Research Funding (with Siddharth George [NUS, Singapore] and Vijayendra Rao [World Bank])	$180,000
2020-21	The Weiss Fund (IPG 2020)	$22,000
2019-20	Warburg Fellowship (with Emily Breza [Harvard] and Arun Chandrasekhar [Stanford])	$7,500
2018-19	The Weiss Fund (with Chinmaya Kumar [University of Chicago])	$31,385
2018-20	The Weiss Fund (with Emily Breza [Harvard] and Arun Chandrasekhar [Stanford])	$69,810
2018-20	Rockefeller Grant for Technology and Governance (through the IDFC Institute, Mumbai)	$300,000
2015-16	JPAL GI Travel/Proposal Grant	$4,500
2014-15	GSAS Fellowship in honor of Amartya Sen	

Research Experience during PhD:

2018-19	IDFC Institute, Senior Research Associate
2016-17	Economist, Office of the Chief Economic Adviser, Ministry of Finance, Government of India

Professional Activities

Referee	*American Economic Review, Journal of Political Economy, American Economic Journal: Applied, American Economic Review: Insights, American Economic Journal: Policy, Review of Economics and Statistics, Journal of Human Resources, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Economic Growth, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization, Journal of Public Economics, Economic Development and Culture Change, Journal of Politics, Journal of Development Studies*
Seminars/Conference Talks	*BREAD (Zurich, 2026), BREAD (Stanford, 2026), Indian Statistical Institute (2025), NEUDC (Tufts University, 2025). American University Seminar Series (2025), NLSIU Bangalore (2025), SNU Mahabalipuram (2025); IIM Bangalore (2025), IIT Delhi (2025), Azim Premji University (2024/25), National University of Singapore (2024), Georgetown University Economics Seminar Series (2024), World Bank DEC Seminar (2024)*, NEUDC (*Tufts 2025. Harvard University 2023, Northwestern 2019), MWIEDC (University of Chicago 2024), UCSD India Seminar Series (2023), Indian Statistical Institute (2023), Delhi School of Economics (2023), Paris School of Economics (2023), Ashoka University (2022), Centre de Sciences Humaines (2022)*, *IFPRI (2022), John's Hopkins SAIS (2022), NEUDC (2019), ISI Delhi Conference (2018, 2019, 2021), The Lakshmi Mittal and Family South Asia Institute (Harvard)*
Media Appearances	*Ideas of India podcast, Mercatus Center (2025), NDTV India, Scroll.in, Newslaundry*

Languages

English, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu, Hindi